Thrilled, Abul Fazl rushed forward.

The rest is history.

~

More than once, in the *Akbarnama*, Abul Fazl portrays himself as a shy and lonely character dragged into the material world despite himself. When he arrived in Fatehpur for the second time, Abul Fazl says he had no friends in the city, that 'there was no kind person to console me'. Yet, he continues piteously, '[m]y youth would not allow me to ask for assistance'.[5] What pulled him out of his shell was the all-powerful emperor, his near-divine muse. 'What portion can a bewildered, headless and footless mote have in the beams of the world-lighting Sun? It can only be tossed about in the wind,' he wrote in his preface to the *Akbarnama*.

Others saw Abul Fazl differently. The authors of the *Maathir-ul-Umara*, a who's who of the Mughal nobility compiled in the eighteenth century,[6] describe a gregarious, generous man. He kept a lavish table, for example, with 22 seers (about 20 kg) of food served every day; in the first and last military expedition of his life, he had 1000 dishes cooked for every meal, mostly to be distributed. Abul Fazl would never dismiss an employee, the *Maathir-ul-Umara* goes on, nor ever fine or otherwise punish anyone, no matter how poorly they performed. Every year, he would burn his books of account (to eliminate all debts, presumably) and give all his clothes to his staff.[7] The reticent bookworm, if at all he ever existed, must have blossomed in the warmth of Akbar's patronage.

But success does not guarantee popularity. Badauni's pen is never so acidic as when he describes his 'officious . . . openly faithless', colleague, 'continually studying the Emperor's whims, a flatterer beyond all bounds'. It was by such 'time-serving qualities', writes Badauni, that Abul Fazl raced through the ranks, while – 'poor I'! – Badauni 'could not manage to advance myself'.[8] Even Badauni suggests, however, that it wasn't only the usual currying for favour and promotion that animated Abul Fazl. The young scholar came to court not so much to make his own fortune, but to destroy the ulema that had persecuted his family. 'He is the man,' writes Badauni, 'that set the world in flames.'

Whether or not Abul Fazl really daydreamed of setting alight an old world